

Chapter 87-1

What followed was an even longer silence than before. The System seemed not to know how to answer Liang Shi's question.

After a long time—so long that Liang Shi thought the System would forcibly go offline to avoid the matter—

That eerie mechanical voice sounded again: 【Sorry, Host. Because you are the first person to bring up this matter, Little Tong just urgently went to discuss it with the higher-ups.】

Inexplicably, Liang Shi let out a breath of relief.

Good—there was room for discussion, which meant there was hope.

"What was the result of the discussion?" Liang Shi asked.

System: 【Since the swap between you and the original owner was a subjective accident, we are currently correcting a past mistake. The Bureau has taken into consideration that the original owner grew up to become what she is now due to significant objective environmental interference. Therefore, if the Host is willing, you can compile the interference factors the original owner experienced during her growth. The Bureau will use this as important evidence to apply for a re-examination on behalf of the original owner. This evidence will also serve as an important reference when the Interstellar Court reopens the case for retrial, and they will consider reducing the original owner's punishment accordingly.】

【PS: Please note, Host—if you choose to accept this mission, your mission duration will change to indefinite. That is, until this mission is completed, the System will accompany you as you grow, until the mission is finished.】

【Another PS: This mission is optional. There is no reward and no punishment. Once accepted, it cannot be abandoned—until death.】

【Little Tong's friendly reminder: Even if you obtain enough evidence, it will only serve as grounds for sentence reduction and cannot be a key factor in releasing the original owner. If the original owner wants to leave the Interstellar Prison, she must pass the interstellar labor reform and the danger level test conducted by detection instruments. If the Interstellar Court's assessment of her is "mild," she can be released once her danger level reaches S.】

【Most most most importantly, Host, you don't need to do so much for her! (Many things won't be useful just because you do them.)】

"I choose to accept." With only slight hesitation, Liang Shi chose to take on this mission.

Currently, she and Xu Qingzhu had already sorted out quite a few clues. The most impactful one was arranging for the original owner to live in a "coffin room"¹ for nearly seven years.

A normal person would go crazy if they didn't die first.

As for the matter with Yang Jiani, Liang Shi was more inclined to believe it was something Qiu Zimin had done to herself².

But Liang Shi felt that what Qiu Zimin did to the original owner went far beyond this. She had intended to drive the original owner insane from the start, so there must be more evidence to uncover.

A scene had once appeared in Liang Shi's dreams—it had only appeared that one time.

It was an image of the original owner trapped in a dark room, being whipped.

That incident should also be related to Qiu Zimin, but she didn't know who Qiu Zimin had sent her to that time.

Anyway, the System said to collect interference factors from the growth process to help reduce the original owner's culpability. It didn't say how many needed to be collected.

Liang Shi now had at least one in hand, so she could choose to pause this mission at any time.

Liang Shi accepted this mission with almost no psychological burden.

The System still didn't know Liang Shi's thoughts. The moment Liang Shi chose to accept, the System froze for two seconds and emitted a grating, crackling electrical sound that made Liang Shi's scalp tingle.

"Aren't you going to get this System fixed?" Liang Shi asked. "You're so rich—fixing a System should only take a minute, right?"

System: 【There's nothing wrong with me!】

Liang Shi: "..."

Her head was about to malfunction from that electrical noise.

After being teased by Liang Shi, the System continued the previous topic: 【I already reminded you that some things won't be useful even if you do them. Why don't you ever listen? A Host who doesn't heed the System's words will surely suffer losses before their eyes. The Interstellar Court's sentencing standards are mostly based on the criminal's mental danger level assessment. The two complement each other, so the Host's evidence can only serve as reference. The Bureau will do its best to help, but it may not necessarily be able to.】

Liang Shi: "..."

That's not what you said just now.

But this System often manipulated her before issuing missions, then showed a different face after she accepted.

Liang Shi was already used to it.

Besides, even if it was useless, she still wanted to try.

"Don't you have to do something first to know if it's useful or not?" Liang Shi's gentle tone revealed confidence. "If you think about the meaning of everything before doing it, then there's no point."

System: 【...】

How annoying!

Got lectured again.

Footnotes:

¹ **Coffin room (棺材房):** Refers to the extremely small, cramped room that the original owner was forced to live in during her childhood. The term "coffin room" is used in Chinese to describe tiny living spaces that are barely larger than a coffin, emphasizing how inhumane and psychologically damaging this living arrangement was.

² **Done to herself:** This is slightly ambiguous in the original text. It could mean either (a) something Qiu Zimin arranged to happen to Liang Shi (the original owner) rather than to Yang Jiani's daughter, or (b) the incident with Yang Jiani was orchestrated by Qiu Zimin against the original Liang Shi. Based on context from earlier chapters, this refers to Qiu Zimin sending the young original owner to Yang Jiani's house where she was abused.

Chapter 87-2

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This time, Liang Shi had essentially accepted three missions simultaneously, and she also knew that she had previously accumulated 96 Luck Points.

Just one step away from one hundred.

Yet 6 Luck Points were still deducted from her.

Liang Shi felt that this System probably wanted to achieve some kind of balance and didn't want her to complete the mission too early.

Moreover, after the mix-up last time, it would try to keep the deducted Luck Points within a safe range.

If this had been announced under the eighty-tier system, the System probably would have deducted more than just 6 Luck Points.

In a way, this was still pretty good.

After all, Liang Shi had indeed... violated the rules.

But at that time, she hadn't intended to gain Xu Qingzhu's trust through that method—she had simply wanted to express herself.

How could someone who had drunk too much remember all those things? Even the travel mission was completed because Xu Qingzhu took her.

Thinking about it this way, Liang Shi suddenly felt that here, she was like a lucky salted fish¹.

Missions were often completed passively.

She glanced at her account. The money from the System had already been deposited. She now had over two million yuan in hand.

Save a bit more and she could make a down payment.

Life was looking up!

Lost in her random thoughts, Liang Shi fell asleep. Even in her dreams, she was buying a house.

When she woke up in the morning, Liang Shi accidentally touched a soft button, and the curtains automatically opened. Sunlight poured into the room, warming her entire body.

Only then did she notice the remote for the electric curtains. She had been in such a hurry to sleep last night that she had casually tossed it on the bed.

At least it was fine—it hadn't suddenly opened the curtains in the middle of the night while she was sleeping.

That would have been like a ghost story.

While washing up in the morning, Liang Shi recalculated the missions. The one with a three-day time limit was relatively simple—she could use the excuse of celebrating her joining the production crew to complete it.

She just didn't know if Xu Qingzhu would need to work overtime recently.

When she came out of the bathroom, Xu Qingzhu was already in the kitchen.

Her slender figure was bathed in sunlight. The place that was much smaller than before added a touch of warmth.

Liang Shi leaned against the doorframe and smiled lazily. "Good morning, Teacher Xu."

"Morning." Xu Qingzhu took out the fried egg, then turned to look at Liang Shi. "Do you want to eat?"

Liang Shi looked closely and saw that one side was burnt.

She smiled helplessly. "I'll eat it."

But Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "Forget it. I'll fry another one."

She was about to dump it in the trash when Liang Shi grabbed her wrist. "It's fine. I'll just remove the burnt part."

Seeing that Xu Qingzhu was still hesitating, Liang Shi had already pinched off a bit and fed it to herself, praising exaggeratedly, "Teacher Xu's cooking skills have improved!"

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her sideways. "You do it. I'm going to wash up."

Liang Shi smiled and pinched off the whitest, most tender part to feed her. "Really, try it yourself. It's fried just right."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She was a bit annoyed while eating, so she bit down exaggeratedly—and even bit a section of Liang Shi's finger.

Liang Shi's hands were fair and had just been washed. They still carried a fresh rose scent from the newly bought hand soap by the sink.

Xu Qingzhu simply took the opportunity to bite down hard on her finger.

Her moist tongue tip happened to slide across Liang Shi's fingertip, and warm lips wrapped around her finger.

Liang Shi was stunned.

Xu Qingzhu quickly retreated.

There was now a faint but visible teeth mark on Liang Shi's finger. After a moment, she smiled and teased Xu Qingzhu. "Teacher Xu, are you this hungry in the morning?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "I wanted to eat meat."

Liang Shi: "But you can't eat human flesh."

Xu Qingzhu turned and left the kitchen. Her cool voice carried the laziness of just having woken up. "I insist on eating it."

Liang Shi: "..."

It wasn't until the bathroom door closed that Liang Shi came back to her senses.

She looked at the teeth mark on her finger, shook her head helplessly, and grabbed a paper towel from the counter to wipe away the glistening moisture.

Meanwhile, after entering the bathroom, Xu Qingzhu leaned her body against the door and lightly knocked her head against it.

What was she just doing?

But the coolness still lingered on the tip of her tongue. The sensation of her teeth grazing across the fingertip was exceptionally clear. Her finger slowly moved to her own lips, and she pressed them together lightly. Her pale lips gradually regained their color.

Xu Qingzhu stood in front of the sink and looked in the mirror, discovering that her earlobes had turned red.

She lowered her head and cupped some water to splash on her face. The sensation of water droplets falling on her lips made her subconsciously lick them. She then tried lightly biting her own finger.

...

What was she doing?

Xu Qingzhu patted her forehead, and water droplets splashed onto the mirror.

She didn't dare continue thinking about it.

Footnotes:

¹ **Lucky salted fish (幸運鹹魚):** As mentioned in previous chapters, "salted fish" (鹹魚) is Chinese slang for someone who lies around doing nothing, like a dead preserved fish. A "lucky salted fish" refers to someone who achieves success or completes tasks without putting in much effort—essentially winning while doing nothing, which is exactly Liang Shi's situation with her missions being completed passively.

Chapter 87-3

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After living in this neighborhood for two days, Liang Shi found the experience extremely pleasant.

She picked a time when Zhao Xuning might be free and started consulting her about buying a house.

But Zhao Xuning replied with complete sincerity, "I don't know. The butler handles all the buying."

Liang Shi: "..."

Fine, how impressive that you have a butler!

Without a butler, Liang Shi could only search online. There were a few secondhand properties listed in the area, but they all required full payment upfront. The money she had on hand was still a bit tight.

The dream of buying a house that she'd had at night was thus shattered.

Two days before joining the production crew, she went to see Liang Xinzhou.

She had originally wanted to meet outside, but Liang Xinzhou didn't want to go out. He sent her an address and told her to come directly.

After moving out of the old residence, Liang Xinzhou and Yu Wan lived in an upscale neighborhood by the river. Before going, Liang Shi first went to the mall to buy some health supplements for Yu Wan, then made a detour to the supermarket for fresh fruit—finally looking like a proper guest.

The upscale neighborhood had good privacy, and the entry procedures were quite complicated. Liang Shi lingered at the entrance for a while before Yu Wan came out to receive her.

Not having seen each other for many days, Yu Wan looked a bit plumper than before, with a rosy complexion. Her color was visibly better than when she was at the old residence.

Liang Shi asked about her and Liang Xinzhou's recent situation, and Yu Wan answered each question.

Yu Wan wasn't much of a talker to begin with. After bringing Liang Shi home, she had the housekeeper pour her a glass of water, then they exchanged a few pleasantries.

When the conversation became somewhat awkward, Liang Shi asked, "Where's Big Brother? Did he go out?"

"He's upstairs in a video conference," Yu Wan said.

Liang Shi: "?"

The surprise on her face was too obvious, so Yu Wan explained, "It's for my family's company."

Only then did Liang Shi slowly nod. She had thought Liang Xinzhou had already returned to Dongheng.

While waiting for Liang Xinzhou's meeting to end, Liang Shi learned from Yu Wan that Liang Xinzhou's phone had been turned off for several days. It was as if he had vanished from the face of the earth—no one could find him.

Yu Wan had also cooperated by turning off her personal number, so no one from the Liang family could reach them.

This apartment was also something Yu Wan had bought before, so even if the Liang family tracked it down, they wouldn't be able to find them.

What's more, Father Liang and Qiu Zimin were currently angry with Liang Xinzhou and wouldn't look for him at all.

After all, it had always been the children revolving around the family business, eager to get more shares. But Liang Xinzhou had directly thrown in the towel, which meant withdrawing from the succession competition.

In everyone's view, with such a large enterprise at stake, the only one who would regret losing it was Liang Xinzhou. So in the end, Liang Xinzhou would definitely be the first to bow his head and return home.

But Liang Xinzhou didn't care.

He had originally joined the company to share his father's burden, thinking that once Liang Xinhe could handle things, he would free up time to help Yu Wan.

Now that this incident had happened, he directly took over Yu Wan's affairs. Yu Wan's parents also trusted him completely—mainly, they had no objections to Yu Wan's decisions.

The two of them living here had quite the feeling of withdrawing from the world.

After hearing all this, Liang Shi couldn't help but sigh. "As long as you two are happy here, that's all that matters. I was worried Big Brother would be troubled by the Liang family matters."

"He's definitely troubled." Yu Wan sighed. "After all, your big brother values loyalty and affection. The night before last, I smelled alcohol on him."

"Right now, you're the priority. Focus on your pregnancy," Liang Shi advised her. "Don't worry about these things. Big Brother will definitely handle everything."

After Liang Shi finished speaking, Yu Wan gazed at her steadily.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi awkwardly touched her nose. "Did I say something wrong?"

Yu Wan shook her head and smiled lightly. "Your big brother said the same thing before."

Liang Shi: "..."

The two looked at each other and smiled. Liang Shi sighed. "Maybe it's because Big Brother has always seemed so reliable."

Liang Xinzhou was indeed a reliable person.

He would shoulder everything and ensure everyone lived smoothly.

But people who had always lived smoothly wouldn't appreciate his efforts.

This was also why Liang Shi had gotten angry at Liang Xinhe that day—talking about it made even herself angry.

Chapter 87-4

Before long, Liang Xinzhou came downstairs after finishing his meeting. Upon seeing Liang Shi, he only nodded slightly without showing much affection. You could only detect some clues from his usually calm and unperturbed eyes—he was happy, because his pupils were bright.

Liang Shi didn't have much to chat with him about either. Talking too much about Liang family matters would easily make one sad, and she had now clearly positioned herself as someone outside the Liang family, so she kept her mouth shut about Liang family affairs.

She only asked if he still planned to return to Dongheng.

Liang Xinzhou's answer was very zen¹. "I'll go with the flow."

Liang Shi understood. The deeper meaning behind these words was: it depends on whether the Liang family still needs him.

If they needed him enough, Liang Xinzhou would still go back.

"By the way," Liang Shi said, "Second Brother asked me to contact you. I refused and ignored him."

"Well done." Liang Xinzhou nonchalantly pushed the plate of fried milk² toward her. "He's pretty busy right now too. Don't take up his time."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi couldn't help but laugh.

"What are you laughing at?" Liang Xinzhou asked.

Liang Shi teased, "Big Brother, I can't believe you're being passive-aggressive toward Second Brother."

Liang Xinzhou glanced at her. "I'm telling the truth."

"Second Brother is having a rough time now too." Liang Shi shook her head. "Busy to death all by himself. He's probably about to explode."

"He brought it on himself," Liang Xinzhou said. "He should think about when I've ever harmed him."

There was a trace of resentment in Liang Xinzhou's voice as he said this.

Liang Shi comforted him. "Don't you know him best? Second Brother just has a soft personality. Isn't Second Sister-in-law the same? They're both good people. They must be feeling caught in the middle right now."

"This is also a lesson for him." Liang Xinzhou lowered his eyes. "There aren't that many win-win situations in this world."

Liang Shi deeply understood this and agreed.

Actually, Liang Shi had thought that conflicts would erupt in the Liang family because of Guo Xinran's arrival. After all, before Guo Xinran came, the one who strutted around that household was the original owner.

No matter how unruly and violent the original owner's personality was, she wouldn't bully her own family members. When Liang Xinzhou scolded her, at most she would let it go in one ear and out the other. She wouldn't hold grudges or seek revenge, and she wouldn't even complain to Qiu Zimin, who always favored her, to have Qiu Zimin seek justice for her.

The same went for Qiu Zimin.

No matter how much she favored the original owner, she wouldn't cause trouble for her eldest son, whom she had always been proud of, because of the original owner. Even if she heard Liang Xinzhou lecturing Liang Shi, she would at most chime in with a word or two from the side.

But Guo Xinran's return was different. Even though she was very well-behaved and the whole family accommodated her, with a large family living together—with children and a pregnant woman—who should yield to whom?

It was hard to reach a conclusion.

It was inherently difficult for a newcomer to integrate into a new environment, and there was no way to please everyone.

Either everyone moved out, or they didn't acknowledge the family ties.

Otherwise, conflicts would erupt sooner or later.

As it turned out, Guo Xinran stepped on a landmine on her very first day.

Liang Shi could only say that Liang Xinzhou had turned misfortune into fortune.

He had found the perfect excuse to move out of the old residence, making it convenient for Yu Wan to focus on her pregnancy.

After eating at Liang Xinzhou's place, Liang Xinzhou asked her about some work matters. Liang Shi gave him a brief explanation, and Liang Xinzhou nodded with a half-understanding.

These weren't within Liang Xinzhou's area of expertise, but Liang Xinzhou had previously acquired a talent agency. He urged Liang Shi to make sure she assembled a professional team, otherwise it would be too exhausting to handle everything alone.

After saying all this, Liang Xinzhou also asked her to relay a few words to Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi was completely clueless about these matters, so she directly typed them into a note and sent it to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu immediately replied: Who told you this???

Liang Shi answered honestly: 【Big Brother.】

Xu Qingzhu: Thank Big Brother for me.

Liang Shi only learned afterward from Xu Qingzhu that the advice Liang Xinzhou had sent would play a crucial role in Minghui Jewelry's later operations.

Because those were all the pitfalls Dongheng had encountered when expanding and going public. As a similar company with overlapping business areas, the path Minghui needed to take was the same path Dongheng had already walked.

It was only then that Liang Shi realized Liang Xinzhou's selfless love for her as a younger sister.

It was a love that transcended blood ties.

Yet at this moment, Liang Shi was like an emotionless message-relaying machine.

As Liang Shi was about to leave, Liang Xinzhou gave her a key, along with the door lock password and a bank card.

Liang Shi: "?"

"What's this for?" Liang Shi waved her hand in refusal. "I really don't want it. Didn't I already say so last time?"

"Take it." Liang Xinzhou frowned. "I've already had the property transferred to your name. From now on, it's your house."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I didn't give you a gift when you got married," Liang Xinzhou said. "Consider this your wedding present."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Xinzhou seemed to be making up for the mistakes Qiu Zimin had made.

Because Qiu Zimin had sold the Shallow Bay villa, Liang Xinzhou wanted to give her back a house.

This realization made Liang Shi's heart skip a beat.

The reason she had initially wanted to keep her distance from the Liang brothers was because she thought that no matter what, they were both Qiu Zimin's biological sons. Even if they knew about the things Qiu Zimin had done, they would at most feel uncomfortable about it, but blood ties couldn't be severed. For Liang Shi, however, it was different.

She very much wanted to expose everything Qiu Zimin had done to the world.

The darkness and hatred that Qiu Zimin had inflicted on a young girl—the obsessive desire to drive her insane—Liang Shi wanted to return it all.

She had even thought that the cruelest thing would be to drive Qiu Zimin insane.

Footnotes:

¹ **Zen (佛系, fó xì):** A popular Chinese internet slang term literally meaning "Buddhist style." It describes a calm, detached attitude toward life—not competing, not forcing things, and accepting whatever happens. Similar to saying "going with the flow" or being very laid-back about outcomes.

² **Fried milk (炸牛奶):** A popular Cantonese dessert made by coating solidified milk custard in batter and deep-frying it until golden and crispy on the outside while remaining soft and creamy inside.

Chapter 87-5

Liang Shi was silent for a moment, then suddenly asked very seriously, "Big Brother, are you compensating me on behalf of your mother?"

This question drew a clear line between them.

Even Yu Wan, standing to the side, couldn't help but furrow her brows. She first looked at Liang Shi and opened her mouth as if wanting to lecture her, but after a moment, she pressed her lips together—probably not wanting to get involved in the dispute between the siblings.

But Liang Xinzhou calmly asked in return, "What do you mean by that?"

Standing there, Liang Shi closed her eyes briefly and said in a low voice, "Because the Shallow Bay house is gone, you're giving me a house to make up for it. Because she brought her biological daughter back, you're compensating me with money. So... are you compensating me on her behalf?"

Liang Xinzhou was also very serious. He looked quite charming when frowning in thought.

After a long while, Liang Xinzhou adjusted his glasses. His voice was calm and reassuring. "Giving you the house and the card are both voluntary actions on my part. They have nothing to do with anyone else."

Liang Shi let out a breath of relief. But after a moment, Liang Xinzhou looked straight at her and asked coldly, "What I want to know more is—what exactly did Mom do to you?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"What exactly happened at Qin Lishuang's house that day?" Liang Xinzhou asked.

Liang Shi was puzzled. "Qin Lishuang? Who?"

Liang Xinzhou was even more confused. "You don't remember?"

After a long silence, Liang Shi came clean. "Big Brother, actually I hit my head a while ago and forgot some things. Some things I'm slowly remembering."

Liang Xinzhou: "...Amnesia?"

Liang Shi nodded obediently.

But Liang Xinzhou asked, "Then what have you slowly remembered?"

"Just some things from childhood," Liang Shi said. "And some miscellaneous stuff. Anyway, I remember the important things, but this Qin Lishuang you mentioned—I have no impression of her."

"Childhood?" Liang Xinzhou's focus wasn't on Qin Lishuang, but rather he asked, "You've remembered things from your childhood?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked.

"How much do you remember about your childhood?" Liang Xinzhou asked.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. She had a feeling that Liang Xinzhou knew something, so she carefully probed, "I remembered Yang Jiani and Qi Jiao."

Now it was Liang Xinzhou's turn to be puzzled. "Who are they?"

Yu Wan, standing to the side, spoke up. "Yang Jiani? Is she the wife of President Qi from Qida Company? And Qi Jiao is her daughter?"

Liang Shi nodded. "Yes. When I was little, I was sent to her house, in a... basement."

Who had sent her there went without saying.

Yu Wan's expression changed drastically. "You were sent to Yang Jiani's place? Why?"

Liang Xinzhou had just managed to match President Qi from Qida Company in his mind but didn't know what had happened.

"What's wrong?" Liang Xinzhou asked. "Is there something wrong with this person?"

Yu Wan said coldly, "Yang Jiani killed her daughter."

Liang Shi was stunned. She hadn't expected that even Yu Wan knew about this.

If she had known earlier, she would have built a good relationship with Yu Wan first. She had gone through so much trouble investigating, only to find out directly from Yu Wan's mouth.

Liang Shi was filled with regret.

But now wasn't the time for regret. She hurriedly asked Yu Wan, "Do you know the details?"